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BIOTECH & HEALTH



**Latent Labs launches
web-based AI model to
democratize protein
design**

About six months after coming out of stealth with [\\$50 million](#) in funding, Latent Labs has released a web-based AI model for programming biology.

[Latent Labs](#)' model has "achieved state-of-the-art in lab results for protein binding," said Latent Labs CEO and founder Simon Kohl, a scientist who previously co-led DeepMind's AlphaFold's protein design team. State-of-the-art, or SOTA, is a term often used in the AI field that represents the industry's best performance to date on a specific task.

"We have computational ways of assessing how good the designs are," he told TechCrunch, adding that a high percentage of proteins the model creates will be viable when tested in a physical lab.

The company's foundational biology model, known as LatentX, enables academic institutions, biotech startups, and pharmaceutical companies to design novel proteins directly in their browser.

LatentX goes beyond what's found in nature, creating entirely new molecule designs with precise atomic structures. This approach can help develop new therapeutics at a much faster rate.

This ability to design entirely new proteins is what distinguishes LatentX from the AlphaFold, according to Kohl.

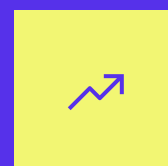
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“AlphaFold is a model for protein structure prediction. So it allows you to visualize existing structures, but it doesn’t let you generate new proteins,” he said.



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In contrast to AI-driven drug discovery companies like [Xaira](#), [Recursion](#), or DeepMind spinout [Isomorphic Labs](#), which focus on developing proprietary medicines, Latent Labs’ business model involves licensing its model for use by external organizations.

“Not every company is in a position to build their own AI models, to have their own AI infrastructure, and to have their own AI teams,” Kohl said.

While LatentX is available for free, Kohl said the company intends to eventually charge for advanced features and capabilities as they’re introduced.

Other companies providing open sourced AI foundational models for drug discovery include

Chai Discovery and [EvolutionaryScale](#).

Latent Labs is backed by Radical Ventures, Sofinnova Partners, Google’s Chief Scientist Jeff Dean, Anthropic’s CEO Dario Amodei, and ElevenLabs CEO Mati Staniszewski.

Topics: [AI](#) [Biotech & Health](#) [DeepMind](#) [Latent Labs](#)



Marina Temkin

Reporter, Venture |

Marina Temkin is a venture capital and startups reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining TechCrunch, she wrote abo...

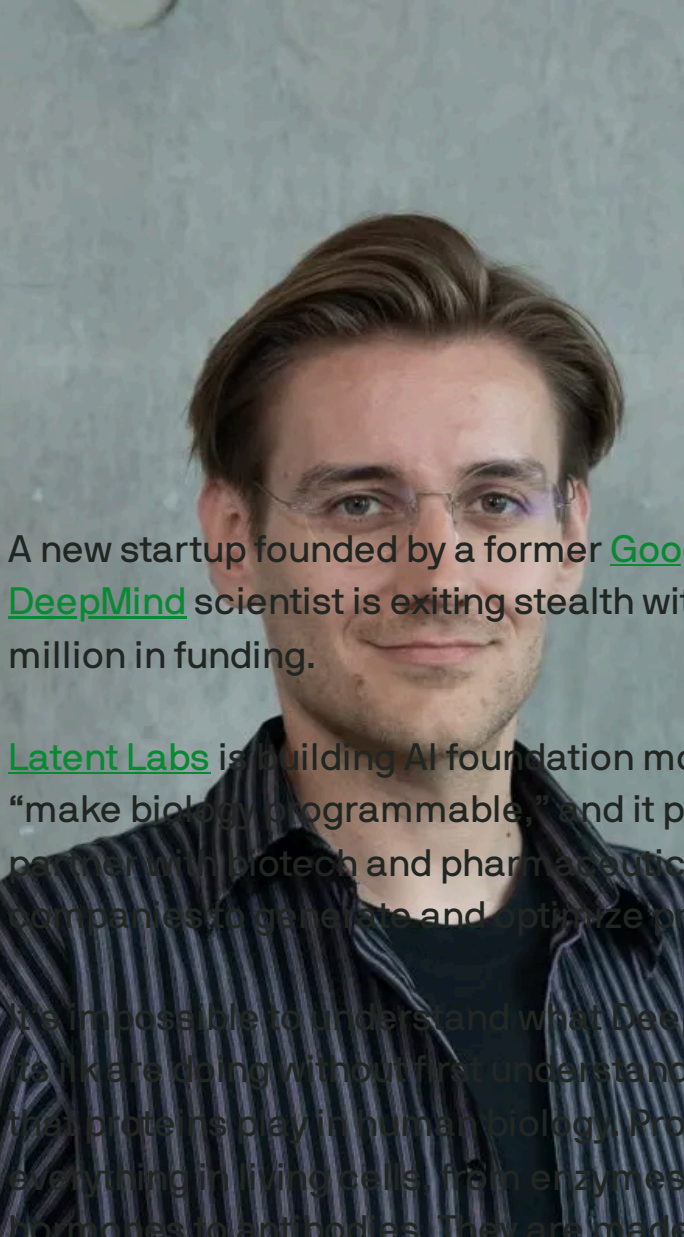
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Founded by DeepMind
alumnus, Latent Labs
launches with \$50M to
make biology
programmable



A new startup founded by a former [Google DeepMind](#) scientist is exiting stealth with \$50 million in funding.

[Latent Labs](#) is building AI foundation models to “make biology programmable,” and it plans to partner with biotech and pharmaceutical companies to generate and optimize proteins.

It's impossible to understand what DeepMind and its ilk are doing without first understanding the role that proteins play in human biology. Proteins drive everything in living cells, from enzymes and hormones to antibodies. They are made up of around 20 distinct amino acids, which link together in strings that fold to create a 3D structure, whose shape determines how the protein functions.

But figuring out the shape of each protein was historically a very slow, labor-intensive process. That was the big breakthrough that [DeepMind achieved with AlphaFold](#): It meshed machine learning with real biological data to predict the shape of some 200 million protein structures.

Armed with such data, scientists can better understand diseases, design new drugs, and even [create synthetic proteins](#) for entirely new use cases. That is where Latent Labs enters the fray with its ambition to enable researchers to “computationally create” new therapeutic molecules from scratch.

Latent potential

[Simon Kohl](#) (pictured above) started out as a research scientist at DeepMind, working with the core [AlphaFold2](#) team before co-leading the protein design team and [setting up DeepMind's wet lab](#) at London's Francis Crick Institute. Around this time, DeepMind also spawned a sister company [in the form of Isomorphic Labs](#), which is focused on applying DeepMind's AI research to transform drug discovery.

It was a combination of these developments that convinced Kohl that the time was right to go it alone with a leaner outfit focused specifically on building frontier (i.e., cutting-edge) models for protein design. So at the tail end of 2022, Kohl departed DeepMind to lay the foundations for Latent Labs and incorporated the business in London in mid-2023.

TC

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“I had a fantastic and impactful time [at DeepMind], and became convinced of the impact that generative modeling was going to have in biology and protein design in particular,” Kohl told TechCrunch in an interview this week. “At the same time, I saw that with the launch of Isomorphic Labs, and their [plans based on AlphaFold2](#), that they were starting many things at once. I felt like the opportunity was really in going in a laser-focused way about protein design. Protein design, in itself, is such a vast field, and has so much unexplored white space that I thought a really nimble, focused outfit would be able to translate that impact.”

Translating that impact as a venture-backed startup involved hiring some 15 employees, two of whom were from DeepMind, a senior engineer from Microsoft, and PhDs from the University of Cambridge. Today, Latent’s headcount is split

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LATENT LABS’ LONDON TEAM (L-R): ANNETTE OBIKA-MBATHA, KRISHAN BHATT, DR. SIMON KOHL, AGRIN HILMKIL, ALEX

While wet labs are very much on the near-term agenda in terms of validating Latent’s technology’s predictions, the ultimate goal is to negate the need for wet labs.

“Our mission is to make biology programmable, really bringing biology into the computational realm, where the reliance on biological, wet lab experiments will be reduced over time,” Kohl said.

That highlights one of the key benefits to “making biology programmable” — upending a drug-discovery process that currently relies on countless experiments and iteration that can take years.

“It allows us to make really custom molecules without relying on the wet lab — at least, that’s the vision,” Kohl continued. “Imagine a world where someone comes with a hypothesis on what drug target to go after for a particular disease, and our models could, in a ‘push-button’ way, make a protein drug that comes with all of the desired properties baked in.”

The business of biology

In terms of business model, Latent Labs doesn’t see itself as “asset-centric” — meaning it won’t be developing its own therapeutic candidates in-house. Instead, it wants to work with third-party partners to expedite and de-risk the earlier R&D stages.

“We feel the biggest impact that we can have as a company is by enabling other biopharma, biotechs, and life science companies — either by giving them direct access to our models, or supporting their

discovery programs via project-based partnerships,” Kohl said.

The company’s \$50 million cash injection includes a previously unannounced \$10 million seed tranche and a fresh \$40 million Series A round co-led by Radical Ventures — specifically, partner [Aaron Rosenberg](#), who was formerly head of strategy and operations at DeepMind.

The other co-lead investor is Sofinnova Partners, a French VC firm with a long track record in the life sciences space. Other participants in the round include Flying Fish, Isomer, 8VC, Kindred Capital, Pillar VC, and notable angels such as Google’s chief scientist Jeff Dean, Cohere founder Aidan Gomez, and ElevenLabs founder Mati Staniszewski.

While a chunk of the cash will go toward salaries, including those of new machine learning hires, a significant amount of money will be needed to cover infrastructure.

“Compute is a big cost for us as well — we’re building fairly large models I think it’s fair to say, and that requires a lot of GPU compute,” Kohl said.

“This funding really sets us up to double down on everything — acquire compute to continue scaling our model, scaling the teams, and also starting to build out the bandwidth and capacity to have these partnerships and the commercial traction that we’re now seeking.”

DeepMind aside, there are several venture-backed startups and scale-ups looking to bring the worlds of computation and biology closer together, [such as Cradle](#) and [Bioptimus](#). Kohl, for his part, thinks that we’re still at a sufficiently early stage, whereby we still don’t quite know what the best approach will be in terms of decoding and designing biological systems.

“There have been some very interesting seeds planted, [for example] with AlphaFold and some other early generative models from other groups,” Kohl said. “But this field hasn’t converged in terms of what is the best model approach, or in terms of what business model will work here. I think we have the capacity to really innovate.”

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[Simon Kohl](#)



Paul Sawers

Senior Reporter | [X](#)

Paul was a senior TechCrunch writer based in London, who focused largely (but not exclusively) on the world of UK a...

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AI



DeepMind’s latest
AlphaFold model is more
useful for drug discovery

Nearly five years ago, DeepMind, one of Google's more prolific AI-centered research labs, debuted [AlphaFold](#), an AI system that can accurately predict the structures of many proteins inside the human body. Since then, DeepMind has improved on the system, releasing an updated and more capable version of AlphaFold — [AlphaFold 2](#) — in 2020.

And the lab's work continues.

Today, DeepMind revealed that the newest release of AlphaFold, the successor to AlphaFold 2, can generate predictions for nearly all molecules in the Protein Data Bank, the world's largest open access database of biological molecules.

Already, [Isomorphic Labs](#), a spin-off of DeepMind focused on drug discovery, is applying the new AlphaFold model — which it co-designed — to therapeutic drug design, according to a [post](#) on the DeepMind blog, helping to characterize different types of molecular structures important for treating disease.

New capabilities

The new AlphaFold's capabilities extend beyond protein prediction.

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DeepMind claims that the model can also accurately predict the structures of ligands — molecules that bind to “receptor” proteins and cause changes in how cells communicate — as well as nucleic acids (molecules that contain key genetic information) and post-translational modifications (chemical changes that occur after a protein’s created).

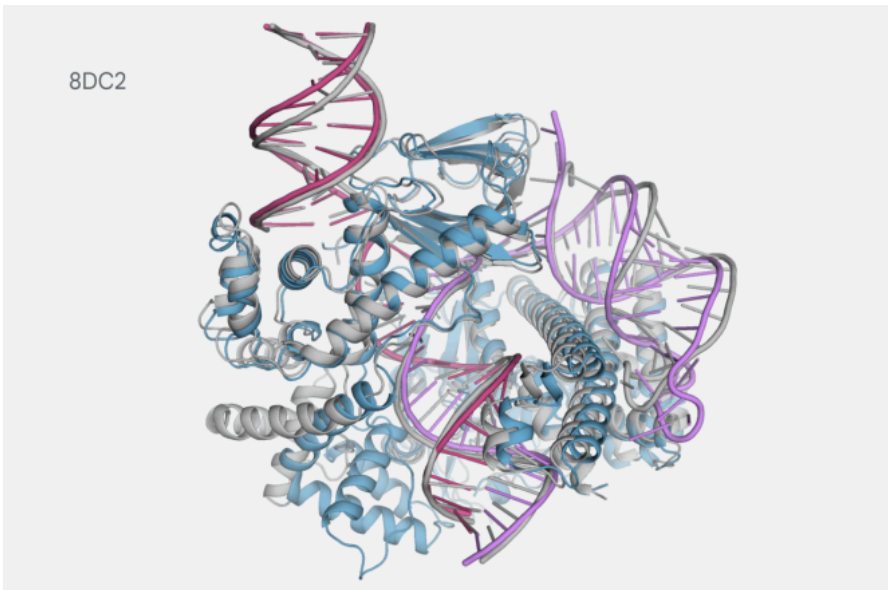


IMAGE CREDITS: DEEPMIND

Predicting protein-ligand structures can be a useful tool in drug discovery, DeepMind notes, as it can help scientists identify and design new molecules that could become drugs.



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Currently, pharmaceutical researchers use computer simulations known as “docking methods” to determine how proteins and ligands will interact. Docking methods require specifying a reference protein structure and a suggested position on that structure for the ligand to bind to.

With the latest AlphaFold, however, there's no need to use a reference protein structure or suggested position. The model can predict proteins that haven't been “structurally characterized” before, while at the same time simulating how proteins and nucleic acids interact with other molecules — a level of modeling that DeepMind says isn't possible with today's docking methods.

“Early analysis also shows that our model greatly outperforms [the previous generation of] AlphaFold on some protein structure prediction problems that are relevant for drug discovery, like antibody binding,” DeepMind writes in the post. “Our model's dramatic leap in performance shows the potential

of AI to greatly enhance scientific understanding of the molecular machines that make up the human body.”

The newest AlphaFold isn’t perfect, though.

In a [whitepaper](#) detailing the system’s strengths and limitations, researchers at DeepMind and Isomorphic Labs reveal that the system falls short of the best-in-class method for predicting the structures of RNA molecules — the molecules in the body that carry the instructions for making proteins.

Doubtless, both DeepMind and Isomorphic Labs are working to address this.

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Kyle Wiggers

AI Editor |

Kyle Wiggers was TechCrunch’s AI Editor until June 2025. His writing has appeared in VentureBeat and Digital...

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